A USER MANUAL · EDITION 5.2

RTMcompare

Pro mastering tools, minus the wall of jargon.

Hi. RTMcompare is the app that tells you what's wrong with your master before your client does — or worse, before the streaming service does it for you.

Drop two files. We say what's different.
Drop one file. We give it a full check-up.
Drop a folder. We help you ship the album.

Read this front to back, or skip to the bit you need.
Chapters are short. Nobody asked for a textbook.

CHAPTER ONE

Install and first launch.

1. Open the DMG. Drag RTMcompare into Applications.
2. Right-click → Open the first time. macOS calms down after that. (Welcome to Gatekeeper, by the way.)
3. The app opens to a single drop frame. Drag two audio files in to start. That's the whole onboarding.

No installer wizard, no license server, no telemetry, no cloud sign-in. The app phones home exactly zero times unless you opt in to live DSP delivery status — and even then it's read-only, with your credentials kept in the macOS Keychain. Your audio stays put.

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Disk: ~600 MB (app + bundled Python + Demucs cache).
RAM: 8 GB minimum, 16 GB if you do stem separation.
Audio: WAV, FLAC, AIFF, AIF, MP3, OGG, M4A, ADM BWF.
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CHAPTER TWO

Compare two files.

Compare is the one most people open first. Two files in, every measurable difference out, in plain English.

Drag the reference into the left slot. Drag the mix you're working on into the right. Pick a delivery target from the chips up top — Music, Full Mix, Broadcast, Netflix, Post. That chip is the gold one; it tells the whole screen which yardstick to use.

Click Compare. Both files level-match to −18 LUFS before you hear them, so a louder master can't fool your ears into thinking it's the better one. Analysis runs locally. Nothing uploads.

When it lands, the strip across the top shows LUFS, TP, LRA, MONO with deltas. Each tab opens with a big headline number — the verdict for that lens — and then drills in. Click around. It won't bite.

CHAPTER THREE

QC a single master.

No reference? No problem. Drop one file in and hit Analyze Reference Only. The app reads it like a tech doing a thorough service appointment.

Clicks and glitches plotted on a clickable timeline — tap any peak and playback jumps right to it. Distortion (clipping, inter-sample, harmonic) with the offending band named, not just a red blob. Mains hum at 50 or 60 Hz plus harmonics, so a ground loop shows up at a glance. Limiter artefacts — pumping, intermodulation, stuck-fast release — flagged with a severity rating.

Then the analog-tape rogue's gallery: wow, flutter, DC drift, tape transport rumble, print-through. And generation loss — the fingerprints of an MP3 or AAC encode hiding inside what someone called the original.

Plus key, BPM, harmonic ladder. Mono fold per band (see exactly where the kick or vocal disappears), stereo image, and per-band phase. Everything you'd normally check across four plug-ins, on one page.

CHAPTER FOUR

Walk an album.

Drop a folder. RTMcompare opens every audio file inside and gives you a sortable table — LUFS, TP, LRA, ISRC, duration, sample rate, bit depth — with outliers highlighted automatically. The whole album at a glance.

Click any row to open that song in a tab. ← → flips between tracks. Deep analysis runs once per song and caches after, so flipping back is instant.

Cohort Mode is the sneaky-good one. Pick any track (or an external file) as the reference, and the app shows a per-band heatmap of how far each song drifts from it. Sort by drift, find the outlier, fix it.
Album consistency, solved.

Save the whole session as a .rtmalbum.json — every analysis, every note, the references, the delivery state. Re-open it in a year, pick up where you left off. (Or hand it to the next engineer. They'll thank you.)

CHAPTER FIVE

Immersive and Dolby Atmos.

Drop an ADM BWF file. RTMcompare reads the bed and objects, follows the trajectories, meters the binaural render, and QCs the stereo downmix against the immersive master. All four jobs, one panel.

Atmos Preflight runs the hard checks Apple actually enforces: objects □ 118, LFE has to route, bed layout 7.1.2 or 5.1.4, sample rate 48 kHz, bit depth at least 24. Anything that fails gates the export. Better to find it here than in the rejection email.

Per-object anomaly detection flags hot, silent, static, or dark objects — usually a mix mistake, not an artistic choice. The flag points at the channel; the engineer makes the call.

CHAPTER SIX

Companion tools.

RTMprofile

Feed it 5+ of your finished masters. RTMprofile learns the spectral and dynamic shape of your sound — bass weight, midrange tilt, top air, dynamic range, the lot. It saves the result as a JSON profile that drops into RTMcompare's Match tab. Now any new mix can be graded against your own catalogue, with concrete EQ moves to close the gap. Your sound, made portable.

RTMsend

VST3 / AU plugin. Sits on a bus in Wavelab, Logic, Pro Tools, Studio One — anything that hosts AU or VST3. One button sends what's playing into RTMcompare's Single, Compare-B, or Album surface. No export dialog. No render queue. ARA-aware where the host supports it; rolling last-N-seconds ring buffer everywhere else.

REFERENCE

Keyboard shortcuts.

Space	Play / pause the active transport
A · B · X	Switch A · Switch B · Flip (ABPlayer)
← · →	Previous / next song (song tab)
1-9	Jump to tab N (Compare view)
M	Mono listen mode (ABPlayer)
S	Solo each side (ABPlayer)
L	Toggle loop
⌘K · /	Command palette · Song quick-switch · Search
⌘E · ⌘⇧E	Export EQ (FFP) · Apply EQ + bounce
?	Keyboard-shortcut legend
⌘N	New comparison (results screens)

Privacy.

Every analysis, every render, every metadata read — all on this device. Audio never leaves. The only network path the app opens is opt-in DSP delivery status: outbound, read-only, with credentials kept in the macOS Keychain via safeStorage. That's it.